before her and the cause for which she has taken a particular position or stand. She then ably leads from the front and takes full responsibility for the consequences of her actions. She takes risks while she commands. She is ready to face the bullets or the swords. And she protects her colleagues to the hilt. One has only to overhear her juniors' conversations to discover the rare admiration she enjoys. They literally follow her on her missions and offer their unstinted loyalty. This is where Kiran's strength comes from, repeatedly, as it becomes evident through innumerable incidents in her career.

In the case of lawyers' strike, for instance (see Chapter 11 for details), she herself was nowhere in the picture to start with. The issue began with the demand for the suspension of a subinspector from the police station under her charge who, contrary to the court's earlier ruling not to use handcuffs, barring exceptional circumstances, handcuffed a lawyer while taking him to be produced before judicial courts in a public transport bus. Even her additional commissioner of police, Rajendra Mohan, at that time, had recommended that she suspend the person temporarily and, when matters cooled down somewhat, she could reinstate him. She, however, let her innate sense of fair play dictate her response. The subinspector, she maintains, was alone and there was sufficient proof of the offender's doubtful antecedents. He was travelling in a public transport vehicle, with the offender in tow, out of compulsion as he did not have any other alternative. Moreover, to prevent the offender from escaping and to ensure his safe custody he *had to* handcuff him. The court's earlier decision on handcuffing pertained to a threat perception and, in this case, according to the police officer, it existed. The offender turned out to be a member of the legal profession, and, as a consequence, large sections of fellow lawyers launched an agitation, essentially seeking the dismissal of Kiran. She stood her ground and courageously faced the lawyers' agitation.

One fact stands out clearly though. It was *not for herself* that she took the stand that offended the lawyers. It was for a junior member of her force whom her judgement had rendered blameless of any fault and any mala fide intentions in the sincere execution of his duties. That, she has always believed, should never be punishable, whatever be the compulsion or expediency. It was the same in the case of the towing incident of the car belonging to the Prime Minister's Secretariat, which had taken place earlier. Then also she had backed the action of subinspector Nirmal Singh to the hilt. (See Chapter 6 for details.)

There seems to be an overriding element of compassion that dictates this quality of fair play in her. This feature can be seen by her response to the endless cases that people brought to her for justice even though she was not officially involved in them. Women kept visiting her house to complain of excesses committed by their husbands upon them. She was asked to intervene in cases of allegedly wrong arrests made by the police personnel who were not even under her jurisdiction. Small kids making a living by polishing shoes surrounded her during her rare shopping forays to Connaught Place and complained about how they were being harassed and prevented from plying their trade.

When Kiran was the DCP (West), she had assured the people that she would ensure that not a single case of unjustified arrest would take place in her area. One of the reformed and rehabilitated erstwhile criminals of the area had started to earn his living by selling vegetables. A dacoity was committed in the South District and, on the basis of this person's criminal record, the South District Police arrested him. His relatives came to Kiran and accused her of breach of trust. She explained to them that the matter did not fall under her jurisdiction but she would still conduct her own investigations to ascertain the truth. Her investigations revealed that injustice had indeed been done and that the accused person could not have possibly committed the crime. She approached the commissioner of police, P. S. Bhinder, with the details she had collected and requested him to review the matter in that light. Bhinder curtly ticked her off, saying the case was not under her jurisdiction